

STARTER

Common Refusal Reasons & How to Avoid Them

United Kingdom - Standard Visitor Visa

UK visitor visa refusals are decided by an Entry Clearance Officer (ECO) against Appendix V: Visitor of the Immigration Rules. Unlike some other countries, there is usually no in-person interview for a Standard Visitor visa - your paper application and documents are what the decision is made on, which makes getting the written application right especially important.

The core requirements under Appendix V

To qualify, you broadly need to show that you are a genuine visitor who will leave the UK at the end of your visit, that you won't work or study in a way that isn't permitted, that you can support yourself and any dependants without public funds, and that you can cover your onward or return journey. Most refusals trace back to one of these not being clearly evidenced.

The most common specific reasons

1. Not a “genuine visitor” in the ECO's assessment

This is the visitor-route equivalent of an intent-to-return concern: the ECO isn't convinced your circumstances support a genuine, temporary visit.

How to avoid it:

- Be specific about your itinerary and purpose, and keep it consistent across the form
- Evidence ties at home: employment, family, property, or ongoing study
- Avoid vague or inconsistent statements about how long you'll stay or what you'll do

2. Insufficient or unclear financial evidence

How to avoid it:

- Provide bank statements covering a reasonable recent period, not a single snapshot balance
- If someone else is funding your trip, include their evidence and a letter explaining the relationship and their commitment - see the Cover Letter and Sponsor Letter templates
- Make sure the funds shown are proportionate to your stated trip length and plans

3. Activities that look like unauthorised work or study

How to avoid it:

- Only select and describe activities that fall within the permitted visitor activities list

- If your trip includes business activities, describe them precisely (e.g. “attending meetings with [company]”) rather than vaguely as “business”
- Don't describe a study plan that amounts to a full course - short recreational courses are generally fine; anything resembling a full-time course of study isn't

4. Incomplete or inconsistent immigration history

How to avoid it:

- Disclose all previous visits, visas, refusals, and any overstay or breach honestly
- Be ready to briefly explain a past refusal in your cover letter if reapplying

5. Missing or poorly organised supporting documents

How to avoid it:

- Since most decisions are made on paper, a complete, well-organised document set matters more here than in visa routes with an interview
- See the Document Checklist (Essential tier) for what to include

A refusal isn't final

There's no formal right of appeal for most visitor visa refusals, but you can request an Administrative Review in specific circumstances (broadly, where you believe the ECO made a case-working error) or simply reapply with a stronger application. See the Refusal Decision Guide (Premium tier) for detail.